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HANDBRAKE

HandBrake is an open-source, GPL-licensed, multi-platform, multi-threaded video transcoder, available for Mac OS, Linux and Windows. Although, you can use it to rip DVDs for producing either high-quality or space saving files, HandBrake is not technically a ripper. Without the addition of extra libraries, HandBrake cannot break the latest copy protection on DVDs, but the application is quite a powerful encoder. The interface of this light application is fairly simple. It has function buttons at the top, followed by three zones for source, destination and output settings. "Output settings" has several tabs that allow you to tinker with various picture, audio and other additional settings. The right panel comprises Preset encoding modes such as Animation, Apple iPod and Normal.



Encoding in various formats

HandBrake saves all files in the MP4 container. This file format has some advanced features such as chapter support and variable frame rate and is fairly compatible with most decoders and devices. MP4 is also the native file format for Apple products such as the iPod. However, HandBrake can encode file formats in addition to MP4 — M4V, MKV, AVI and OGM. To select a file format, click on the Format drop down menu under Output Settings. Depending on the container or file format, you can choose the Video Codec from there. HandBrake offers four encoding options, namely, FFmpeg, XviD, H.264 and VP3 (Theora). H.264 is the new preferred HD encoding format. To select a Codec, click on the video tab under Output Settings.



Ripping select chapters

At times, you may want to extract certain chapters of a DVD movie. It

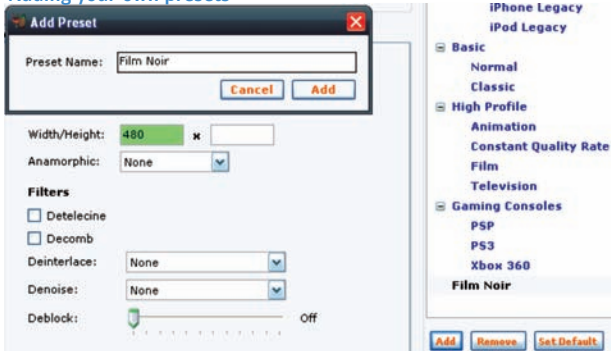
may be for showcasing, posterity, or any other reason. To rip certain chapters of a DVD, select the source by clicking the Source button at the top-left corner. Set the destination output file in the Destination bar (for example D:\temp\Crash). Next, select the title and chapters to rip. By default, the longest title, which is the movie, will be selected by the application. Select the range of chapters you wish to encode below the source bar (say chapters 1 through 4). The estimated time of the selection will be displayed alongside. HandBrake can also append chapter names to the output files. This is very useful if you are ripping more than one file. To change these settings, click on Tools > Options. The general tab in options allows you to change the default output path too. In the main interface, make necessary video and picture settings by using the various tabs or use one of the presets. You can even edit chapter names and markers in the Chapters tab. Once you're ready, click the start button to start encoding. To rip the entire DVD, select all chapters.



Using presets

There are several minor settings that go into tweaking the video while encoding. Some

Adding your own presets



difference to the overall picture quality are frame rate, bit rate, encoding type (whether 2-Pass or not), container, height/width and decomb. HandBrake provides many pre-programmed. For example, if you choose the Animation preset under High Profile, the output file format will automatically change to MKV and several minor changes will take place under the different tabs that deliver best output for animation movies. If you wish to encode something for viewing on an iPod, the preset will take care of resizing the video. All you have to do is select your preferred preset and start ripping. Advanced users can save their own tweaks to a preset. To save a preset, click on the Add button at the bottom of the preset panel and give your preset a name. Your custom settings will be saved.



Burn subtitles into movies

HandBrake has the ability to burn or superimpose on top of a video permanently. This is called hard-burning, which means that it cannot be switched off. There are two types of subtitles — one that runs throughout the movie and the other that shows up only during certain instances. HandBrake allows you to burn either of the two types of subtitles. To change these settings, click the Audio & Subtitles tab and select the options from the dropdown menu. The options are none, autoselect, and the tracks that the application detects such as English and Spanish.



Encoding in HD

HandBrake allows encoding in high definition (H.264). The presets relating to this mode of ripping are clubbed under High Profile. It's best to use a preset, but advanced users can manually input some of the options. Another important option is the deblocking filter. This filter smoothes blocky compression artifacts when you play back the video. It has two settings — strength and threshold similar to image editing. Each can go up to +/- 6. If strength is below zero and towards the negative, blurring is reduced. Positive values create a softer image, while lower threshold numbers will blur lesser details. 0.0 is the default, but different settings can be used to render different types of material. Live action for instance is good with values such as -2,-1 or -2,-2. To change these settings look under the Advanced tab in the main interface.



Queuing

Since encoding is a time consuming process, it's handy to be able to queue multiple encoding jobs. HandBrake allows you to queue tasks with the "Add to queue" button on the top toolbar. All you have to do is set up the first encode and click start. Now while this first encode takes place, change the title, chapter, or source in use, for the next set of encodes. Be sure to rename the destination file. Tweak any